

Atleast 35% of Indian mobile users will click an unsafe link

Global mobile malware business will turn profitable in 2012

While it's all exciting on the smartphone and tablet roadmap all through this year, there's a grim forecast emerging from security watchdogs monitoring malware trends. McAfee, Kaspersky, and other security specialists are unanimous in their prediction that Android smartphones will be the most targeted in 2012 -- 75 million unique malware samples by December 2011, according to McAfee, and most of them targeting Android. With close to 1 million device activations daily, there's no wonder why spammers and scammers are targeting Google's mobile OS.

Another agency specializing in cross-platform security solutions for smartphones, Lookout has even more bad news. SMS pick-pocketing malware like

GGTracker and RuFraud will only multiply in number this year, and malvertising (real ads that link back to poisoned sites) will grow with increased mobile advertising revenues. While there's a 35 per cent likelihood of Indian and Australian smartphone users succumbing to a browser attack, US smartphone users will have it worse off where over 40 per cent will hit a fraudulent link.

Lookout also warns that mobile botnet networks will be a serious issue in 2012. The threat of cleverly deployed app and browser attacks to secretly ensnare unsuspecting mobile devices into an extensive network like Droid-Dream or Gemini which distributes spam, malware software and compromises private data is very real. We should all have a

security app installed on our smartphones to provide a certain measure of protection from external threats. **d**



Handheld gaming goes beyond social games

Party begins with better hardware and cloud integration

In many ways, 2011 was the year for social games on mobile devices. While the theme isn't going to disappear in a hurry, casual games with better graphics seems to be an emerging trend for handheld devices in 2012; also gaming on a cloud infrastructure.

With the advent of Tegra 3 tablets and dual-core smartphone chipsets this year, look forward to game developers stepping up the experience a few notches. That's right, more Infinity Blade-like games, with console and PC-like graphics and a less-casual, more-immersive, richer gaming experience. Similarly, game streaming services like OnLive and Gaikai will gain more traction, as cellular broadband becomes faster, more affordable and widespread. It's a great way to play free demos of full video games.

Enough on mobile gaming, what's happening with specialized game consoles? The recently launched Sony PlayStation Vita along with the Nintendo 3DS will spearhead their charge on fans with exclusive games and high quality titles. Apart from the obvious successor to the aging Xbox 360 console, is Microsoft working on a Vita competitor? If yes, we might see the first announcement of such a device later this year.

While social gaming won't be as big as it was last year, its main proponent, Facebook, will ensure community gaming is alive and kicking. Changes to Facebook's Open Graph will have a positive impact on social games, with Facebook users able to see in real-time what games their friends are playing.

This will ensure a more rewarding end-user experience. **d**

